

2.2 From DOS to Windows XP

In the beginning, there was darkness; and out of that darkness there came a light. “A:\”, it said, and the world was happy.

Grandpa—MSDOS

MSDOS (Microsoft Disk Operating System) was Microsoft’s first operating system for the PC. It dominated the scene through the ’80s, and carries on till today, albeit in a less important role. It was actually developed by Seattle Computer Products, who called it QDOS—the Quick and Dirty Operating System. Microsoft then bought the system from them for just \$50,000 and changed it to MSDOS. DOS was a simple system—it only let one program to run at a time, and gave it full control of the machine. If a program crashed, there was no other option but to reboot.

DOS gave ‘drive letters’ to each disk drive on your system—‘A:’ and ‘B:’ were the floppy drives, and if you were lucky enough to have a hard drive, it would be called ‘C:’. DOS organized these disks into files and directories, and used the FAT (File Allocation Table) to keep tabs on them.

DOS filenames consisted of two parts—an eight-letter name, and a three-letter extension, both separated by a dot ‘.’—For example, “filename.ext”. The file’s extension told DOS what type of file it was, and which program to use to open it.

Users spoke to DOS using a *Command Line Interface*. Put simply,

The heart of MSDOS

Io.sys: This let DOS communicate with the hardware through the BIOS (The Basic Input/Output System)

Msdos.sys: This was the DOS kernel

Command.com: This is where all the DOS commands were stored and interpreted

Config.sys: Hardware configuration information was stored here

Autoexec.bat: All the programs that were supposed to run at startup were called here